

The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in someone belief a reason for doubt?

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a small black and white dog with curly hair. Suppose you form the belief that my dog is a poodle.

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs are quite popular in the area, and also of that size with those markings.

It looks like you would now have found a reason for doubting your initial belief.

More precisely, it looks like you would have realized that there is a possibility of your belief being false which you are unable to rule out.

And, as the quote from Descartes suggests, it seems reasonable for you now to stop believing that my dog is a poodle, and instead to suspend judgement about whether it is a poodle, or a Havanese, or perhaps some other small back and white type of dog.

This suggests the following rule of belief:

Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P.

“As I think about this more carefully, I see plainly that there are never any sure signs by means of which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep.”

In fact, there is nothing special about the example of being asleep. The basic point Descartes is making here is that there are never any sure signs by means of which I can distinguish between having an accurate sense experience of the world around me and (on the other hand) having an experience which does **not** reflect the way that the world around me really is.

A dream is one example of the second kind of experience; but there are plenty of others. Consider ordinary perceptual illusions and hallucinations. Or we can consider more far-out examples, like the idea that are in some sort of virtual reality simulation.

The key thing about all of these examples is that (i) the subject's experiences are not accurate representations of their world but (ii) they are indiscriminable, from the subject's point of view, from experiences which are accurate. Reflection on these examples suggests that, for every experience you have, there is a **matching** illusory or dream experience which is indiscriminable from it.

Further, because these matching illusion experiences feel exactly the same from the inside as accurate experiences, it seems that you have no way of ruling out the possibility that your current experience is an illusion of one of these kinds.

Imagine that I have hidden an object behind the lectern. I ask you to consider the possibility that it is green, and that it is red. Can you rule out either of these possibilities? No, because things look just the same to you whether the hidden object is red or green.

In this scenario it seems obvious that you should not form the belief
that the object is red or that it is green.

But Descartes' reflections on dreams and illusions suggest that this case is exactly parallel to the beliefs about the external world that you form on the basis of ordinary experience.

Just as your experience of the red object possibility and the green object possibility feel just the same to you (because the object is obscured from view), so accurate experiences feel just the same to you as matching illusory or dream experiences. So it seems that you have no way to rule out those possibilities, in which all of your beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience are false.

There are situations which I cannot rule out which would make beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience false.

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